

Many stuck on the standard path through life are mesmerized by celebrity culture, reality TV, and lotteries. They believe you need a big break to become rich. They can't envision a path to a better ending for their story, so they never bother trying to write it.

Those who *Choose FI* don't have a crystal ball that reveals the ending to their stories either. We start anyway. There are remarkable success stories in the FI community. Some achieve FI in less than a decade on average salaries. School teachers become millionaires. Some people retire in their forties, thirties, or even twenties! The magic that enables these extreme stories is not really magic at all. These seemingly overnight success stories don't happen overnight. They are the result of the aggregation of marginal gains.

This concept of aggregating marginal gains is explained well on the *ChooseFI* podcast by Barney, who writes the blog *The Escape Artist*. He tells the story of a cycling coach who, when asked about the key to his Tour de France team's success, replied that his cyclists brought their own pillows when traveling. On the surface, this answer sounds absurd. How can the pillow you sleep on be the difference between winning and losing among world-class athletes? In isolation, it can't. But none of the decisions we make necessarily occur in isolation.